The Excerpt of the Chapter on Māra from the Ninth Fascicle of the Great Uṣṇīṣa

Toh 237 · Derge Kangyur

གཙུག་ཏོར་ཆེན་པ་བོམ་པ་དེ་གུ་ལུ་ལས་བདུད་ཀྱི་ལེའུ་ཉིད་ཀྱི་ཚོ་ཕེད་བ།

The Excerpt of the Chapter on Māra from the Ninth Fascicle of the Great Uṣṇīṣa, known in Tibetan as Tsuktor Chenpo Bampo Gupa Lé Dü kyi Le'u Nyitsé Chungwa, is a short sūtra extract drawn from a scripture referred to as the Great Uṣṇīṣa (in Sanskrit, Mahoṣṇīṣa), which corresponds to the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra, and early Tibetan catalogues record that it was translated from Chinese. In it the Buddha instructs his disciple, addressed here as Ananta, on the subtle demonic states that can arise in deep meditation as each of the five aggregates of form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness is progressively exhausted. He describes the visions, false insights and wrong views, including various non-Buddhist doctrines of permanence, annihilation and false nirvāṇa, that a meditator may mistake for the fruit of the noble ones, and warns that clinging to them opens the way for Māra, while simply recognizing them for what they are is without fault. The text closes by urging that this teaching and the Buddha's protective mantra be passed on to future beings so that they may not go astray. It is Toh 237 in the Kangyur, where it is placed in the General Sūtra section.

From the ninth section of the Great Uṣṇīṣa: a partial extract of the chapter on Māra.

The Blessed One (the Buddha) said, "Ananta, you should understand it like this. When one abides in the seat of awakening, all perceptions will be refined away. That itself is the abandoning of perception. Thereby the whole essence becomes manifest. Since movement is completely purified, it does not diverge into anything else, and as mindfulness is voiced, it is one with what is genuine. If one abides in just that and enters meditative absorption, it is like a person with sight who sits in great darkness: the purified nature itself is perfectly clean, but because light has not yet arisen in the mind, that is the dwelling place of the form aggregate. When the eyes become clear and one sees the ten directions without obstruction, so that there is no darkness and nothing unseen, that is the exhaustion of the form aggregate, and one passes beyond the turbidity of the eon. When one examines what this is about, it arises from tightly grasping an untrue mind.

"When meditation on that mind becomes empty and peaceful, luminous and clear, in an instant one gains mastery over the body, and the body attains freedom from obstruction by form. That is called merely the arising of the power of purity.

"When that mind is empty and peaceful, luminous and clear, everything that is inside one's own body appears. Even though parasites suddenly emerge from one's body, one sees the body as unharmed and undamaged. That too is merely the arising of the power of pure illumination.

"Because that mind is empty and peaceful within and without, one hears from empty space the sound of the Dharma being taught, and in the ten directions the sound of the profound meaning of the Dharma being explained. That merely comes from the soul, the bodily spirit, the intellect, the will, and the vital essence, which dwell together, coming apart and joining again.

"Because that mind is luminous and clear and an inner light has arisen, all the ten directions take on the color of Jambu River gold. Even sentient beings whose minds are discordant turn into forms of the Buddha. Vairocana is seated in a mansion of divine light, surrounded by ten buddhas, together with a hundred times a hundred thousand lands and realms with their flowers, and one sees all these in an instant. Because the mind and the soul's feeling are sharp, one merely sees those worlds by the subtle light of the mind.

"When that mind is empty and peaceful, clear and luminous, since there is no interruption in examining and analyzing, suddenly in an instant one sees the ten directions turn into the seven kinds of precious substances and into a hundred colors. That merely comes from pressing the mind down and not letting it go, not relinquishing the intensity of meditation.

"Because the mind has become empty and peaceful, luminous and clear, for a while one suddenly sees whatever there is in the darkness of night as if it were daytime. One sees this merely because the mind has become peaceful and clear.

"Because that mind is empty and peaceful, even if one's body is hacked and cut with weapons like grass and wood, or burned in fire, it neither hurts nor burns. That is the characteristic of the four great elements being expelled.

"By the power of that mind becoming pure, all the mountains, rivers, and the whole earth of the ten directions turn into buddha fields adorned with precious jewels, with light shining everywhere. One sees buddhas as numerous as

grains of sand dwelling in the sky, and jeweled mansions in the sky, and, without obstruction, everything from the Avīci hell up to the palaces of the gods. That merely comes from long meditation upon a mind of weariness and delight.

"Through long and minute meditation on that mind, for a while at night one suddenly pervades a town that lies far away, and there is craving for it; it becomes a matter of particles, and one grasps those very things as permanent. Then one seeks the meaning of nirvāṇa in the doctrines of the non-Buddhist (tīrthika) Kāśyapa brahmins, the worshipers of fire, and the worshipers of water, and becomes one of the company of those non-Buddhists. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the view of knowledge is lost. Practicing the doctrine of the non-Buddhists who earlier held that objects exist, one accomplishes an untrue result, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the lineage of wrong views.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus one feels that the mind is empty, and clinging to that mind and inclining toward it, one is born in the abode of the long-lived gods, the sphere of neither existence nor nonexistence. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the seeing of knowledge is lost. This is called the sixth: by grasping the mind as empty, one attains the result of emptiness, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the lineage of annihilation and extinction.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus one grasps the body as permanent and says, 'This body does not die and does not come to an end.' Clinging to that mind, one is born into the retinue of Asita, those who seek long life, both the greedy and the not greedy. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the view of knowledge is lost. That is the seventh: through the untrue cause of attachment to life, one fulfills the result of the long-lived gods, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the retinue of untrue longevity.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor

death. Thus one attains a life without obstruction. Fearing that the sorrows will be exhausted, one conjures up many lotus seats and mansions of the seven precious substances, and indulges the mind in whatever it desires. Because one clings to that, one becomes part of the retinue of Tatikala, both the true and the untrue. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the seeing of knowledge is lost. That is the eighth: a crooked mind is made the cause, one attains a domain of exuberant indulgence, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the lineage of the divine māras."

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus, within the appearance of life, one clears away the appearance of there being no field of activity. Daring to dispel the true and the untrue, cause and result, one turns one's back on the path of genuine purity and clarity. One sees the afflictions, cuts off their origin, knows cessation, and cultivates the path. Abiding in cessation, one gives up the mind that strives onward, and because one clings to cessation, one becomes one of the company of the so-called genuine śrāvakas. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the view of knowledge is lost. That is the ninth: by abiding in a mind at peace, one completes the result of peace, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the lineage of those who grasp at emptiness.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus one feels the genuine mind to be pure and clear, luminous and bright, and by examining it closely one holds it to be the meaning of nirvāṇa. Being also not fully matured in the meaning of cessation, one holds that what inclines of its own accord has a direction. One falls into doubt, thinking, 'My own body and mind also arose from that place,' and says, 'My own body too is truly permanent.' Clinging to that mind, one becomes attached to saying 'permanent' and to saying 'impermanent,' and becomes one of the company of the mighty gods. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the seeing of knowledge is lost. This is called the third, the arising of an untrue result through abiding in the mind. One turns one's back on nirvāṇa and becomes of the lineage of wrong expansion.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in

the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus one feels knowledge expanding upon knowledge, and holds that the plants and trees of the ten directions also have minds, being no different from human beings, so that even when a person dies, he becomes plants and trees. Because one's mind clings in this way, one holds to knowing and not knowing, as the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) do, and becomes one of the company of these Patasa. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the seeing of knowledge is lost. This is called completing an untrue result through a mind that knows expansion as its basis. One turns one's back on nirvāṇa and is born into the lineage of wrong knowing.

"Again, son of noble family, having understood all formations to be empty, one stops birth and death in consciousness itself, but one has not fully matured in the meaning of the peaceful cessation in which there is neither birth nor death. Thus, in utter peace, one gains mastery over the faculties, which are interchanged and can be put to use. Then one seeks the radiance of fire, delights in pure water, and the wind. Some say, 'Form is I.' Some say, 'Form exists.' Some say, 'Form is realized in me.' Some say, 'Sorrow and awakening are each separate; neither belongs to the other.' Saying this, the awakening mind is corrupted, and one becomes one of the company of the perverse non-Buddhists of the sixth non-Buddhist doctrine, who say that within the five aggregates there are signs after death.

"Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of noble family enter the meditative absorption of a straight and unmoving mind. Since Māra finds no opportunity, they examine the source of birth. When they examine form, feeling, and perception, which have already ceased, since all of them have already ceased, then though there was form, form is exhausted; though there was mind, there is no perception; though there was a source, the feeling aggregate is exhausted; though there was the meaning of birth, I now have no present aggregates either. If it is like grass and trees, there is neither cause nor result after death. There is no cause and result of nirvāṇa either. Everything is empty. It merely exists as a mere name, but there is no reality of an essence. Saying this, the awakening mind is corrupted, and one becomes one of the company of the perverse non-Buddhists of the seventh non-Buddhist doctrine, who say that within the five aggregates there are no signs after death.

"Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of noble family enter the meditative absorption of a straight and unmoving mind. Since Māra finds no

opportunity, they examine the source of birth. Seeing that both the feeling and the perception aggregates cease, they demolish the one with the other, and become non-Buddhists who say that after death it is neither of the two.

"Because form, feeling, and perception are present, one does not meet with a wrong meditative absorption. The light of perfect meditative absorption shines forth, and one craves that perfect appearance. When one becomes greedy for the methods of meditative absorption, the divine māra finds an opportunity and enters into that person. He becomes skilled at explaining the Dharma and transforms his body into various forms. He is able to emit light even in darkness, and says, 'In a certain land, a person named so-and-so has become a fully manifest buddha. Three kinds of eon have occurred in this land. Loosen the moral discipline that the Buddha taught!' So he commands, and he teaches nothing but doctrines of desire and craving. As soon as the possessing spirit leaves his body, he and his disciples are caught up in the king's law, and he falls into the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"When feeling has become utterly hollow, the appearance of perfect meditative absorption arises, and one craves an excited meditative absorption. The divine māra gains an opportunity and enters within, and one becomes supremely skilled at explaining the Dharma. One thinks, 'My sorrows are exhausted.' When explaining the Dharma, one sees one's own body turn the color of gold and sit upon a jeweled lotus, and the other people listening to the Dharma become the same, and one thinks, 'I have attained awakening.' The mind becomes distracted, and one destroys the discipline. To some of the listeners one prophesies, 'You will become a buddha in this age.' To others one says, 'I am an emanation of a buddha of another land.' All the people listen respectfully to one's words. Then, as soon as one is parted from the spirit, one and one's disciples are caught up in the king's law, and one goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"When feeling has become utterly hollow, the light of the appearance of perfect meditative absorption arises. Within meditative absorption, because one craves clarity of mind, the divine māra finds an opportunity. Because one is greedy for a body born of the mind, and the subtle mind is not exhausted, the divine māra gains an opportunity and enters into one's mouth, and one explains the Dharma to others. Not feeling that Māra has pierced one, one thinks, 'I have passed into nirvāṇa,' and explains the Dharma to others. In an instant one goes to towns a hundred or a thousand leagues away, takes whatever is there, and shows it to others. Sometimes, inside a house, between

walls that are close together, one makes some people run with all their might, yet even in a year they do not get across. Some believe in one and begin to wonder whether one is the Buddha. One says, 'All the sentient beings of the ten directions are my children. All the buddhas were first born from me. I am the primordial buddha, who arose out of the world.' And one also says, 'Because I command it so, I am the eldest.' That is the divine māra who dwells in the world and has gained mastery. As soon as that māra leaves the body, one is caught up in the king's law and goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"Ananta, understand this! At the time of the final Dharma, those ten kinds of māra will go forth into homelessness within my Dharma. At times of meditation they sometimes enter bodies and sometimes display bodies, and they say, 'All have attained the unsurpassed.' They praise lust and destroy the Buddha's moral discipline. Māra's preceptors and Māra's disciples teach each other the doctrine of lust, and if someone feels that mind and becomes attached to it, then within nine generations at the nearest, and a hundred generations at the farthest, even all those who genuinely practice the Dharma will, after they die, all become māras. They destroy the genuine path and go to the Avīci hell. Ananta, you are the one who, without passing into nirvāṇa, shows the meaning to sentient beings.

"By the power of Māra one explains the meaning of desire, destroys the Buddha's discipline, and eats grass and trees. Since one's practice of the Dharma is inconstant, sometimes one does one thing and sometimes another. As soon as that māra leaves the body, one and one's disciples are caught up in the king's law and go to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"Again, son of noble family, when the feeling aggregate has become utterly hollow, one does not meet with a wrong meditative absorption. Because the light of perfect meditative absorption shines, when one meditates in meditative absorption, the mind craves various unobstructed miraculous powers. The divine māra gains an opportunity and enters into one's mouth, and one becomes skilled at explaining the Dharma. Not feeling that Māra has pierced one, one thinks, 'I have passed into nirvāṇa.' When one explains the Dharma, one holds a lamp in one's hand, cuts off light for the listeners, and distributes the light upon the crowns of the listeners' heads. On those people's heads the light spreads out for many fathoms, yet there is no heat and no burning. Sometimes one runs on water as though running on land. Sometimes one rises into the sky and stays there without moving. Sometimes one enters a

water jar and hides one's body. Sometimes one enters a sack and hides one's body. Sometimes one comes out through a window and goes off. Sometimes one passes through walls without obstruction. Only over weapons has one not gained mastery. With one's own mouth one says, 'I have already become a buddha.' Wearing white clothes, one makes the monks prostrate before one, and slanders them. When one explains the Dharma to others, one teaches nothing but the doctrines of harlots. These are spirits of heaven and earth, of trees and plants, of rivers, and dead vidyādharas, who were born as spirits and went further still to become māras. As soon as that māra leaves the body, one is caught up in the king's law and goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"Again, son of noble family, when the feeling aggregate has become utterly hollow, one does not meet with a wrong meditative absorption. Because the light of perfect meditative absorption shines, when one meditates in meditative absorption, one craves utter cessation and emptiness. The divine māra gains an opportunity and enters into one's mouth, and when one explains the Dharma to others one is supremely skilled. Not feeling that Māra has pierced one, one thinks, 'I have passed into nirvāṇa.' When others come to ask about the Dharma and one explains it, one makes one's body empty so that others cannot see it, and for a while one suddenly appears out of emptiness, gaining mastery over appearing and hiding. Sometimes one shows one's body to be transparent inside and out like crystal. Sometimes one's hands and feet smell of sandalwood. Sometimes even one's urine and filth are like thick sugar. One disparages moral discipline and despises the monks, and says there is no recompense for any action one has done. One says, 'When one dies in this body, it is completely finished there, and there is no taking up of a later body,' and teaches that ordinary people and noble ones are the same. 'We,' one says, 'engage in perverse attachment and lust.' When one teaches the Dharma to others, one says that one's disciples have attained the mind of emptiness. As soon as that māra leaves the body, one is caught up in the king's law and goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes this, there is no fault.

"Again, son of noble family, when the feeling aggregate has become utterly hollow, one does not meet with a wrong meditative absorption. Because the light of perfect meditative absorption shines, when one meditates in meditative absorption, the mind craves long life. Having cast off the body of the four great elements, one gives up striving onward and clings to that, and

so becomes one of the company of the pratyekabuddhas whose minds truly do not turn back. The awakening mind is corrupted, and the view of knowledge is lost. That is the tenth: by equalizing feeling expansively, one completes the result of an unmoving appearance, turns one's back on nirvāṇa, and is born into the lineage of those who do not turn the expansive appearance of feeling toward others.

"Ananta, those ten kinds of meditative absorption become causes of conviction, and they consider themselves to have reached what is sufficient for the supreme. All of them arise from consciousness, the mind, becoming high and low. Inferior beings, not knowing their own measure, dwell in the habitual tendencies of the mind according to whatever they crave, and, not knowing that this is saṃsāra, they hold, 'I shall truly attain unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.' Thereby it becomes a great lie, and they are born in the abodes of the non-Buddhists, of Māra, and of wrong views. When their karma is exhausted, they go to the Avīci hell.

"Teach this meaning of mine to the sentient beings of the future, and have them distinguish it very carefully, so that they do not do the work of the māras. Placing their minds and bodies within the seeing of the Buddha's knowledge, see to it that from beginning to end they do not meet with wrong paths. All the buddhas of the past, as numerous as grains of sand, attained unsurpassed awakening by meditating according to this very gateway of the Dharma.

"When the consciousness aggregate is exhausted, the six gateways are interchanged and can be put to use: at the gateway of the eye one can hear sounds, taste flavors, and feel fragrances. Then one becomes an abode of the profound vajra wisdom of awakening.

"When a luminous, clear, and peaceful appearance has arisen, suddenly countless compassion arises. Even when one sees the very lowest of creatures, one thinks of them as one's own children, and tears flow without one's noticing. If one recognizes this, there is no fault, and after a long while it subsides by itself. If one does not recognize it, the māra of compassion enters within, and even when one meets people, countless sorrows arise, and one falls into crookedness. That arises from squeezing the mind and practicing too intensely.

"Within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. A sublime omen appears before one

and descends upon the mind, so that suddenly fierce diligence arises strongly, and one becomes able to accomplish in a single moment what the buddhas practiced for three countless eons. If one recognizes this, there is no fault, and after a long while it subsides. If one does not recognize it, the māra of madness enters within, and one shows off to everyone one meets. Great pride arises, and one goes astray. That merely arises from practicing too intensely.

"Within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Nothing new is seen ahead, and turning back one does not find the old place either, so that one sees nothing at all. While one stays in this in-between state, suddenly greed and great thirst stir, and the mind sinks, and one thinks, 'This is the sign of diligence.' Because one has no wisdom, the meaning is lost. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra of unmindfulness enters within, and making the mind into a single lump, one falls into crookedness.

"Within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Diligence stirs greatly, and the sublime mind breaks down. The doubt arises, 'I myself am Vairocana,' and one is satisfied with very little. That arises from coarse practice of the mind. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra of contentment enters within, and one falls into crookedness.

"Within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Nothing new is gained, and the old is lost. While one stays in this in-between state, countless sorrows arise. As if lying on a hot iron bed or having drunk poison, one is so unhappy that one wants to die, and wildly urges others to kill one. One cuts one's own flesh, and if one still does not die, one wants to flee to a place such as the mountains or the forests, where one will not meet a single person. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra that causes sorrow enters within, and in the end one kills oneself. That merely arises from losing the method of meditating on the mind.

"Within that meditative absorption, one sees the form aggregate as pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Abiding within purity and clarity, one becomes blissful, and suddenly countless joys arise. This is called the mastery of the mind. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, wisdom has not prevailed: the māra of joy enters within, and when one meets people, one laughs, sings, dances, and so on, and falls into

wrongness.

"Within that meditative absorption, one sees the form aggregate as pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Suddenly the seven kinds of pride stir all at once. One holds that even the buddhas of the ten directions have their limits, and does not count the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as existing at all. That is the pride of views, a wisdom without restraint. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra of pride enters within, and one will not bow even to the Buddha's shrines and images. One commands the donors: 'These are bell metal, copper, cloth, wood, bark, and the like; there is no need to worship them. Worship the true body of flesh!' And one falls into the Avīci hell.

"Within that meditative absorption, one sees the form aggregate as pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Within that empty, peaceful, luminous clarity one sees a great meaning, and suddenly a strongly inclined mind arises, and countless powers of mastery arise in the mind. That is having gained a little mastery through wisdom. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra of mastery enters within. One thinks oneself fully satisfied and is afterward unwilling to be disturbed. Later the mind is stirred, one slanders, and one falls into hell.

"Within that meditative absorption, one sees the form aggregate as pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. Having attained a peaceful luminosity, suddenly there is no cause and no result, and the meaning of emptiness appears before one. If one recognizes this, there is no fault. If one does not recognize it, the māra of emptiness enters within. One tells the monks who keep the discipline, 'That is the Lesser Vehicle. When a bodhisattva has understood the meaning of emptiness, how could there be any form of keeping or breaking discipline?' One commands the donors: 'Eat meat and drink liquor, gamble, and so on!' Through the power of spirits and seizing spirits (grahas), one becomes able to eat even filth as though it were food.

"Within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is pacified, and the feeling aggregate is luminous and clear. The taste of peace penetrates into the mind and the bones, and suddenly a mind of countless cravings stirs. As craving grows, one goes mad and turns to lust.

This is called "the meditative absorption inclined toward the object of bliss." Because one is unable to protect oneself with wisdom, one turns to lust. If one

recognizes this for what it is, there is no fault. But if one does not recognize it, the māra of lust enters within, and one teaches people wrongly, saying, "Lust alone is the path of awakening. Even if you engage in unchaste conduct, practice it as equals!" Because of this one is caught up in the king's lawsuits, and one also falls into the Avīci hell.

These ten kinds of mind in meditative absorption come about as mental activity turns higher or lower. It is merely that the nature of the feeling aggregate is appearing. It is an auspicious sign of virtue, but it is not the fruit of the noble ones. If one becomes attached to it, Māra finds an opening and one falls into error. If one recognizes it for what it is, there is no fault.

Son of good family, as one cultivates that meditative absorption, the feeling aggregate is exhausted. Although the defilements are not yet exhausted, the mind becomes separate from the body, as when a bird is freed from a net, and one's own aim is accomplished. That ordinary body ranges through all the sixty ranks of the bodhisattvas and obtains a mind-made body, so that wherever it goes it meets no obstruction. It is like, for example, an outcaste: although he has no other wisdom, his manner of speech is not confused, and everyone understands him without mistake. This is called "the dwelling of perception."

When the moving, remembering mind is exhausted, the upper layer of untruth melts away and is purified, and the mind that appears and feels becomes like something that has gone free of stain and dust. The course of birth and death appears complete from beginning to end. This is called the exhaustion of the perception aggregate, and one passes beyond the turbidity of the afflictions. It comes about simply from the untrue mind being pacified and becoming unobstructed.

That son of good family views the feeling aggregate as not existing in utter hollowness, and views formations, in the absence of impermanence, as not nonexistent. Examining everything in the same way, he concludes that after death there is no further lifetime, and his awakening mind is ruined. Because the eight kinds of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say that within the five aggregates, after death, there is no ground remaining at all, he comes to belong to the faction of the perverse.

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the meditative absorption of the upright, unmoving mind. Māra finds no opening, and they examine the origin of birth. Thinking, "In the end there is no birth,"

and being mistaken about this, they come to the seven kinds of tīrthika view of annihilation. After the body ceases, desire too ceases, suffering too ceases, great joy too ceases, and great equanimity too ceases. Having examined minutely above and below, they say, "After death there is no birth whatsoever," and their awakening mind is ruined. They come to belong to the ninth faction of perverse tīrthikas, those who, within the five aggregates, hold the view of annihilation after death.

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the meditative absorption of the upright, unmoving mind. Māra finds no opening, and they examine the origin of birth. The tīrthikas who hold that in the end there is birth come to belong to the faction of nirvāṇa. They feel that the desire realm is the ground of the genuine transformation of the basis, and so it becomes cyclic existence. Because in the first dhyāna there is no sorrow, because in the second dhyāna there is no suffering, because in the third dhyāna there is great joy, and because in the fourth dhyāna both pleasure and suffering are absent, they hold these to be free of birth and death. Concerning the gods who still have defilements, they also hold that the unconditioned is impermanent.

In the fourth case, that person holds the perception aggregate to be exhausted and sees the formations aggregate as existing. Because he therefore holds the form aggregate, the feeling aggregate and the perception aggregate to be impermanent and the formations aggregate to be permanent, his awakening mind is ruined, and he comes to belong to the third tīrthika faction, those for whom one part is permanent and one part impermanent.

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the meditative absorption of the upright, unmoving mind. Māra finds no opening, and when they examine the origin of birth, because the mind moves and cannot stay still, four kinds of mind concerning the finite and the infinite stir. First, because birth and death are never interrupted, dying after having been born here is finite; and because the mind has no interruption, it is infinite. Second, when that person examines as far back as eighty thousand eons, he sees that sentient beings exist, and this he holds to be finite; when he examines beyond eighty thousand eons, he sees nothing at all, and this he holds to be infinite. Third, because that person holds, "I know everything," he sees himself as infinite: "All sentient beings appear within my knowing, yet from of old I have not known the names and clans of people." Fourth, because that person holds the formations aggregate to be empty, he sees half of the

bodies of all sentient beings as arising and half as ceasing. Therefore his awakening mind is ruined, and he comes to belong to the fourth tīrthika faction, those who say half is finite and half infinite.

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the meditative absorption of the upright, unmoving mind. Māra finds no opening, and they examine the origin of birth. Because the mind moves and cannot stay still, four kinds of perverse mind stir within the mind that sees knowing. First, seeing the nature of magical transformation, they say, "All is impermanent." When they see signs continuing without interruption, they say, "It is permanent." When they see the place of seeing, they say, "There is arising." When they do not see the place of seeing, they say, "There is cessation." When someone comes to ask about the Dharma, they say only such things as, "It is neither arising nor ceasing, neither existent nor nonexistent, neither increasing nor decreasing," and their words do not even hold together. Second, when they examine the mind, because the mind is not found, when someone comes to ask about the Dharma they explain nothing else and speak only the one word, "Nonexistent." Third, because they examine their own mind, and because the mind has a locus and they see it, when that person comes to ask about the Dharma they explain, "It is that," and say nothing else. Fourth, that person sees both existent objects and nonexistent objects, and when someone comes to ask about the Dharma, the answer given is: "Within the existent there is also the nonexistent;

within the nonexistent there is also the existent." They say such things, and there is no way even to ask them about the Dharma. Their own awakening mind is ruined, and they come to belong to the fifth tīrthika faction, the four kinds of perversion.

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the upright, unmoving meditative absorption. Māra finds no opening, and they examine the origin of births. The mind moves and cannot be contained within, and they hold that the moving mind is infinite. They become tīrthikas who say that after death there are characteristics. They say, "The crow has always been black, and the swan has always been white. Seeing that these have not changed through tens of thousands of eons, there is neither cause nor condition." Deceived about the fruit of awakening, they come to the view of the first tīrthika faction.

Ananta, within the meditative absorption the mind of a son of good family is lucid and clear. His meditative absorption is unmoving and Māra finds no opening. When he examines the origin of births, he comes to know the causes of the birth and death of sentient beings, and four kinds of mind that say "permanent" stir. First, they say, "The mind is permanent." Second, they say, "The four great elements are permanent." Third, they say, "The consciousnesses of the six gates, the mind, and the basis of all are also permanent." Fourth, because the perception aggregate is exhausted, there is no longer any point of birth, and it becomes nonarising itself. Because the mind has become nonarising, they hold the mind to be permanent, and their awakening mind is ruined. They come to belong to the second tīrthika faction, those who say "permanent."

Again, within that meditative absorption, sons of good family enter the meditative absorption of the upright, unmoving mind. Māra finds no opening, and they examine the origin of birth. Seeing the mind as not conceiving, the mind stirs with four kinds of perversion. First, they say, "Wherever it may be in all ten directions, I pervade it." Examining lands as numerous as the sands of the ten directions, they think of the lands where an eon has occurred as impermanent, and of the lands where an eon has not occurred as permanent. Third, examining their own mind, they see the mind as subtle as an atom, and they hold, "Wherever my mind goes in the ten directions, though the body changes, the mind does not change; therefore my mind is permanent. Since all birth and death come from my mind, I see you, my relatives and friends, and everyone there is, and I hear the sound of whatever they say." That is merely seeing and hearing because, through intense meditation, the mind has gone outside. By meditating continuously and minutely on that mind, one sees one's spiritual friends suddenly shifting and changing into various forms. That comes from the mind having gone crooked and from seizing spirits and demons having entered. Now and then a divine māra suddenly enters within, and one becomes skilled at expounding the profound Dharma without hindrance. If one recognizes that this is not genuine, it subsides of itself; if one does not recognize it, one goes astray.

These ten kinds of meditative absorption come about as the meditating mind turns higher or lower. It is merely that the nature of the form aggregate is appearing. It is an auspicious sign of virtue, but it is not the fruit of the noble ones. If one thinks it is the fruit of the noble ones, one goes astray. These things are merely seen suddenly, for a while; if one sees them in that way,

there is no fault. But if one becomes attached to them, one takes an enemy for one's son, and Māra finds an opening.

When the form aggregate is exhausted, seeing the minds of all the buddhas is like seeing forms within the brightness of a mirror. Though there is attainment, there is no using it. It is like, for example, a person in the grip of a demon: though his hands and feet are all intact and his seeing and hearing are not confused, it is as though he were pinned down by a spirit. That is the dwelling of feeling. Thereafter one emerges from within one's own form, looks back at one's face, and is free of remaining in form. One's going has no obstruction, and one gains freedom. That is the exhaustion of the feeling aggregate, and that person is able to cross beyond the turbidity of views. It arises from the untrue mind being pacified.

Within that meditative absorption one obtains a great light and becomes highly skilled at teaching the Dharma. Before the Dharma has been taught, the people listening to it remember their former lives and see the hells, and they come to discern all the good and bad of the human world. Then one thinks, "I too have attained awakening." Letting the mind grow careless, one destroys moral discipline and teaches like this: "This is a great buddha, this a small buddha, this a buddha accomplished earlier, this a buddha accomplished later, this a male buddha, this a female buddha, this a male awakening, this a female awakening." Then, as soon as that spirit leaves the body, one, together with one's disciples, is caught up in the king's lawsuits and falls into the Avīci hell. If one recognizes it for what it is, there is no fault.

Feeling becomes utterly hollow, and one is free of wrong meditative absorption. Light appears within the perfect meditative absorption, and craving the feeling that is the origin of all dharmas, a divine māra gains an opening. Entering one's mouth, it makes one highly skilled at teaching the Dharma. By one's majesty one overwhelms all who listen to the Dharma before it is taught, and one says: "Do not think that the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa. This very body of mine is the Buddha. My unbroken line of sons and grandsons is the permanent Dharma body. There is no pure buddha realm apart from this." Thinking, "I have attained awakening," one lets the mind grow careless and teaches the doctrine of lust, explaining that the five senses such as the eye are the pure domain, and that the male and female organs are the true abode of awakening and nirvāṇa. As soon as that spirit leaves the body, one, together with one's disciples, is caught up in the king's lawsuits and falls into the Avīci hell. If one recognizes it for what it is, there is no fault.

The feeling aggregate becomes utterly hollow, and one is free of wrong meditative absorption. Because a light appears within the perfect meditative absorption, one comes to crave expounding the profound Dharma. For that reason a divine māra gains an opening, enters one's mouth, and one becomes highly skilled at teaching the Dharma. Not recognizing that it is Māra, one thinks that one has oneself attained nirvāṇa. The listeners to the Dharma see one's body for an instant, and like someone meeting anew a relative or friend not met for a hundred or a thousand years, their minds rejoice and they cannot bear to let go; they cling, all the while making offerings. Thinking, "I too have accomplished awakening," one lets the mind grow careless and teaches the doctrine of lust, saying: "In this lifetime I was born in this land and brought this person to liberation. In a former lifetime this person was my wife or my concubine. This person is my brother. I came here for his sake. I will go with you to that heaven over there." And one says, "Elsewhere there is a place where a great light shines; all the buddhas dwell there." Then, as soon as Māra leaves the body, one, together with one's disciples, is caught up in the king's lawsuits and goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes it for what it is, there is no fault.

Because that son of good family's feeling aggregate has become utterly hollow, he does not meet with wrong meditative absorption. Because the light of perfect meditative absorption appears, he strives after the stilling of the mind. A divine māra gains an opening and enters his mouth, and, not recognizing that he is in the grip of Māra, he becomes highly skilled at teaching the Dharma. His listeners, too, each come to know from what karma they have come to be. To some people he declares: "Though you are a human now, you are an animal. If you do not believe it, I will tread on your tail and you will not be able to stand up. Look!" He treads on it just so, and the person cannot stand up, and then others too believe in him. He slanders the monks and destroys the Buddha's discipline. As soon as that māra leaves that person's body, he, together with his disciples, is caught up in the king's lawsuits and goes to the Avīci hell. If one recognizes it for what it is, there is no fault.

Again, that son of good family's feeling aggregate becomes utterly hollow, and he does not meet with wrong meditative absorption. When, through the light of the perfect meditative absorption, he cultivates meditative absorption, his mind craves knowing, seeing, and remembering the past. A divine māra gains an opening and enters his mouth. Not recognizing that he is in the grip of

Māra, he thinks, "I have attained nirvāṇa." When he teaches the Dharma to others, he suddenly holds a precious jewel. The māra transforms its body into an animal, holds a precious jewel in its mouth, and light shines. Suddenly it comes bringing jewels and wondrous, unheard-of riches. At first it gives wealth, and in the end it enters his belly. He shows others, saying, "There are precious jewels under the ground," and light shines up from beneath the earth, so that everyone takes it as a marvel. He gives up meals, and though he eats only medicinal food, or else a single grain of millet or barley, through the power of Māra his condition is good. He slanders the monks and says, "There are treasures in the ten directions, and this place and that are the abodes of the noble ones." Later too, from time to time, such things are seen. That is a spirit of a mountain, a grove, or a fortress, one killed by an enemy and reborn again as a spirit, which has gone beyond that and become a māra. Teaching this is what is called repaying the kindness of the Buddha.

Ananta, these ten kinds of meditative absorption come about as the mental activity of the perception aggregate turns higher or lower; it is merely that the nature of the feeling aggregate is appearing. It is an auspicious sign of virtue, but it is not the fruit of the noble ones. If one thinks it is the fruit of the noble ones, one goes astray. These things are merely seen suddenly, for a while. If one recognizes them in that way, there is no fault. If one does not recognize them in that way, one falls into a state of error.

Ananta, when the perception aggregate is exhausted, sleeping and waking are alike. The mind becomes like space, and one sees the reflections of one's field of experience, and all the mountains, groves, waters and whatever else there is in the world, as if looking into a mirror. There is no place from which they come, and no trace where they go. That is called the dwelling of perception. When the original mind, like waves subsiding, becomes like still water, that is called the exhaustion of the perception aggregate. That person has come out of the turbidity of sentient beings. If one examines its meaning, it arises from the original untrue mind, which is extremely subtle and does not appear.

Ananta, know this: the sons of good family who have attained the genuine meditative absorption are not open even to those ten kinds of divine māra. Then, meditating intensely on the mind, when they examine the origin of births, because the eye faculty has eight hundred qualities, they know how the sentient beings within eighty thousand eons died and how they were born. Thinking, "Within eighty thousand eons sentient beings arose by themselves without cause; humans are born as humans, animals are born as animals, and

birds are born as birds," they see five states as utterly pure and as utterly blissful, and they say, "This is the meaning of nirvāṇa." Their awakening mind is ruined, and they come to belong to the tenth faction of tīrthikas, the perverse ones who, within the five aggregates, hold to five kinds of nirvāṇa.

Ananta, these ten kinds of wrong understanding in meditative absorption all come about in this way because the mental activity of the formations aggregate turns higher or lower. Inferior sentient beings, without having gained any real experience themselves, regard what is not as what is, and think, "I have perfected the fruit of the noble ones." That is a great lie, and they go to the Avīci hell. You and the others, take up this intention of the Tathāgata and teach it to the sentient beings of the future, and do not let the māras of the mind stir. Do not think that having heard a little is enough; become kings of great awareness, and be a pure and clear signpost for all.

Ananta, when the formations aggregate of sons of good family who cultivate meditative absorption is exhausted, it becomes like the stirring of the world. The six faculties become utterly pure and hollow, and the mind no longer has any agitation or inability to stay still. Outside and inside, the meditative absorption is unmoving, and it appears clear.

If one enters, there is no place to enter. One knows the kinds of sentient beings of the ten directions, and sees that the ten directions too are of a common kind. That is called the dwelling of the consciousness aggregate. The six gates are interchanged and can each be used for the others. The realms of the ten directions and one's own body and mind become like crystal, bright and clear outside and inside. That is called the exhaustion of the consciousness aggregate. That person has passed beyond the turbidity of life. If one examines its meaning, it arises from the untrue mind having become inverted while the true meaning was only dimly coming forth.

Ananta, know this! When a son of good family understands all formations to be empty, birth and death cease within the emptiness of consciousness. But because he is not fully developed in the meaning of the peace and cessation in which there is no birth and no death, he says, "The true cause is permanent." Clinging to that in his mind, he comes to belong to the faction of the tīrthika Kapila. His awakening mind is ruined, and his knowing and seeing are lost. He becomes the first kind of tīrthika, the one who holds that the mind exists. He turns his back on the true meaning and is born in the lineage of tīrthikas.

Ananta, when a son of good family understands all formations to be empty, birth and death cease within consciousness itself. But because he is not fully developed in the meaning of the peace and cessation in which there is no birth and no death, he holds the true itself to be "I myself," thinking, "All the twelve kinds of sentient beings throughout space and all the realms have come from my body." Because he clings to that in his mind, he comes to follow the tradition of the tīrthika Maheśvara. He emanates countless bodies and makes them his retinue; his awakening mind is ruined, and his knowing and seeing are lost. This is called a mind that can act as creator and a fruit that can accomplish aims. He turns his back on the ability to truly pass into nirvāṇa and is born among the gods of great pride.

Again, when a son of good family understands all formations to be empty, birth and death cease within consciousness itself, and the peaceful mind in which there is no birth and no death is like a precious moon within pure crystal. When it becomes so, one attains the bodhisattva's ten faiths, ten abidings, ten practices and ten dedications. Passing beyond the bodhisattva's vajra-like meditative absorption and the ground of equal awakening, one enters the vast illumination of the Tathāgata and attains the meaning of the adorned ocean of awakening, in which nothing whatever is attained. Then, within the calm abiding and insight of the buddhas of the past, when the extremely subtle deeds of Māra and domains of Māra appear before one, one recognizes them all and washes away the stains of the mind. One does not fall into wrong views. The māra of the aggregates melts away and the divine māra is crushed. One is not born among the gods, demons and rākṣasas, nor among the powerful spirits, and so, until one straightaway accomplishes awakening, nothing is lacking. The mind of great nirvāṇa becomes clear and is not ruined.

The faculties of sentient beings of the future will be dull. They will crave meditative absorption, and because they do not understand meditative absorption, they will fall into wrong states. Ananta, teach my mantra and this meaning, just as they are, to the sentient beings of the future. If they cannot recite my mantra, let them write it down and carry it on their body, or fasten it to the room where they cultivate meditative absorption or to the door of their dwelling. Then all the divine māras and the rest throughout the ten directions will melt away and be unable to do harm. Ananta, do not forget that; teach it for the sake of all sentient beings.

From the ninth fascicle of the Great Uṣṇīṣa, the excerpt of the Chapter on Māra is complete.

In the three earlier catalogues it is said to have been translated from Chinese.

Here is volume Zha of the Sūtra section.

Translator's Notes

• This text was translated into Tibetan from the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra, and the addressee Ananta (Tibetan Thayé) corresponds to Ānanda in the Chinese. The list "the soul, the bodily spirit, the intellect, the will, and the vital essence" renders Tibetan terms that appear to reproduce Chinese words for the components of the spirit (hun, po, yi, zhi, jingshen); "soul" reads □□□ ("thigh") as □□, as again later in the passage, and □□□ and □□□□□□□ are sound-spellings of the Chinese. "Palaces of the gods" reads □□□□□□ ("gods' servants") as □□□□□□. The words rendered "worshipers" (□□□□) are read in light of the Chinese parallel, which speaks of serving fire and venerating water. The extract passes directly from the ninth state of the form aggregate to the states of the consciousness aggregate, as the Tibetan stands. Tatikala could not be identified with confidence and is given as spelled.
• This text was translated into Tibetan from the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra, and its phrasing is often obscure; several sentences are rendered literally where the sense is uncertain. "The sixth non-Buddhist doctrine" reads □□□□□□□ as a contraction or slip for □□□□□□□□□□□□□, matching "the seventh non-Buddhist doctrine" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□) that follows and the numbered heresies of the Chinese parallel. "All the people" reads □□□□□□□□ as □□□□□□□□□. Patasa is given as spelled; it seems to render the name of a non-Buddhist group in the Chinese, and could not be identified with confidence.
• Several readings follow the evident sense and the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra from which this text was translated. "To towns a hundred or a thousand leagues away" renders the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□. "One says, 'All the sentient beings ... are my children'" reads □□□□□ ("the angry") as a slip for □□□□□ ("I") and □□□□□□□□□□ as □□□□□□□□□□ ("all ... my"). "Since one's practice of the Dharma is inconstant, sometimes one does one thing and sometimes another" renders a repetitive and elliptical sentence.
• Three readings follow the evident sense and the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra from which this text was translated. "Countless sorrows" reads □□□□□□□□ as □□□□□□□□□□□□. "A peaceful luminosity" reads □□□□□□□□□ ("fourfold appearance") as □□□□□□□□. "The taste of peace" reads □□□□□□□□□ ("a dead corpse") as □□□□□□□□□.
• This section corresponds to the account of the demonic states of the feeling, perception and formations aggregates in the Śūraṅgama Sūtra, of which this Tibetan text is a translation from Chinese; the numbering of the tīrthika factions follows this Tibetan as it stands rather than the Chinese order. The simile "like an outcaste" (mi gdol pa) is translated as written; the Chinese parallel has a person talking in deep sleep, and the Tibetan may reflect a misreading. In the third view on the finite and infinite, the syllable bzhin before "that person" has been read as bzhir, "fourth," which the sequence clearly requires. "Comes to this Dharma" (chos 'dir 'ongs) in the first of the last four views has been read as chos 'drir 'ongs, "comes to ask about the Dharma," as in the following sentences. The statement that they hold the unconditioned to be impermanent for the defiled gods is rendered as written; the Chinese speaks of mistaking the defiled heavens for the unconditioned.
• As in the preceding piece, this Tibetan follows the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra loosely and out of order; it is translated as it stands. The crow and swan saying reflects the Chinese parallel ("crows have always been black, swans always white"); the Tibetan wording is compressed. In the list of four perverse views the ordinal for the second is missing in the Tibetan. "Leaves the body" renders lus la 'phags, which is unusual and seems to stand for the spirit departing, as in

the Chinese parallel. The simile of the person "in the grip of a demon" corresponds to the Chinese image of someone paralysed in a nightmare.
• As before, this Tibetan follows the Chinese Śūraṅgama Sūtra loosely and is translated as it stands. Several phrases are obscure: "he strives after the stilling of the mind" renders rang 'grus 'bogs kyi sems zhi ba la 'grus, which is unclear; the sentence about the spirit of a mountain, grove or fortress "killed by an enemy" and the phrase "repaying the kindness of the Buddha" are compressed and their connection is uncertain. "Kings of great awareness" renders tshor ba chen po'i rgyal po, where tshor ba stands for the Chinese "awakening" (jue) rather than the aggregate of feeling; "signpost" renders tshon ma, matching the Chinese "pure marker". "Like still water" renders "like water and earth," which corresponds to the Chinese "becoming clear water."
• "Kapila" renders sa phyi la, a sound-spelling that corresponds to the Chinese transcription of Kapila, the founder of Sāṃkhya, in the parallel passage of the Śūraṅgama Sūtra. The phrase "a mind that can act as creator" renders the obscure dang 'og byed nus pa'i sems, read in the light of the Chinese parallel ("the mind as agent, the fruit of accomplishing agency"). "Ten dedications" renders phyogs bcu, here standing for the Chinese "ten turnings toward" (dedications), not the ten directions; "equal awakening" renders snyoms pa'i tshor ba, the Chinese "equal enlightenment."

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.